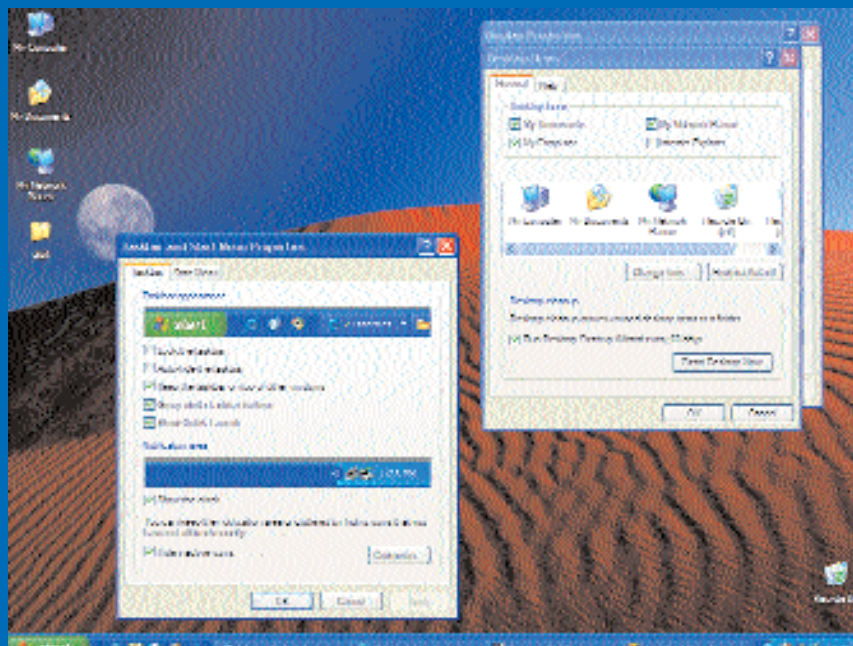


Easier to Explore

Start menu is presented in two columns. The left pane remembers the frequently accessed applications and files and positions them for easy access. It is visually more appealing than the earlier versions.

Desktop

1. Bolder and more colourful icons highlight the desktop, adequately describing its function.
2. The Quick Launch icons can be concealed, thus saving a certain amount of taskbar space.



3. Multiple windows of a single application can be grouped together saving space on the taskbar and giving it an organised look.
4. Icons in the system tray can be hidden from view. Clicking on the arrow expands the list, showing the inactive icons.
5. The Recycle Bin is the only icon XP installs by default.
6. Various options help you customise the desktop. And if you miss the icons of the earlier versions, you can get them back.

not forced to reboot or turn off the PC even once. Certain applications such as Internet Explorer 6 and StarOffice did manage to crash, but the problems were isolated and didn't have any effect on the rest of the system. Since XP runs each application in its own memory space, the chances that a single application will cause your machine to crash is reduced.

Exploring the Window

A typical Windows XP Explorer window—with the contents on the right and an overview window on the left—is intelligently crafted to let you jump to other sections of the computer as soon as you click.

The improved icons in XP complement Explorer quite well. You can now change the icon of any file or folder at the instruction; photographs can be used as well.

For MP3 files, ID3 tags and bit rates are displayed. When you arrange your Explorer window to show all file details, information such as song name, artist, year, etc, is mentioned.

Explore through images in a filmstrip manner. When you highlight the image's icon, a preview pane opens up giving

you the bigger picture. You can also use this to create a basic slide show. XP displays image file information (such as photos and scanned objects) in detail—everything from resolution to which camera captured the image.

Windows Explorer now comes with the ability to handle the .zip compression format. Compressed files can be opened without additional software. If you want to package a few files together, just select what you want and right-click your way through the correct option.

With Web integration features, you can directly copy files to an online storage service, order picture prints of your images, and purchase and download MP3s. You can disable this Web integration feature if you don't have Net access.

Multimedia militia

Windows XP has done a thorough job in providing users with a complete multimedia solution. As mentioned before, one of the more obvious components in XP's multimedia arsenal is Windows Media Player (WMP) 8.0. It now adds the ability to play from DVDs, provided you have a DVD codec installed. XP offers in-built support to make your own audio CDs from WMA and MP3 files.

This is certainly useful but XP provides only a fraction of functionality that full-scale software offers. This would mean anybody interested in 'ripping' audio CDs to the MP3 format will be sorely disappointed—WMP does not permit that. What it does permit is the conversion of audio to WMA format. Though WMA is gaining popularity, it's nowhere near MP3s in terms of popularity. For those of you who need help in playing back DVDs or encoding MP3s, search for codecs and add-ons on the Web.

Video time

Video plays a prominent role in XP. You can run a slew of devices to capture video, edit and make simple movies, and XP now supports high-speed video interfaces such as FireWire. Picking up from where Window Me left off, XP has adopted Windows Movie Maker to make the entire task of moviemaking easy. However, this is far from a fully-featured video studio and is not meant to be taken seriously by professionals. Don't expect an Oscar yet!

Help

If you've used Windows before, you'd know how the help files are segregated from one another. No more messy business in XP—all help files can be



Microsoft and its partners spent a collective amount of about \$1 billion on marketing Windows XP

